is full of walking trails, all of which afford stellar views. The kitchen here serves carefully preserved royal family recipes, while the imperial dining room, the wooden ceilings, crystal chandeliers and artefacts together all speak of a bygone era when kings had both taste and power.
(karanmahalsrinagar.com; INR 28,000 plus taxes with breakfast and dinner)

Dar-es-Salaam

Situated by the Nageen Lake, Dar-es-Salaam (Haven of Peace) does much to live up to its name. Barely seven kilometres from the city centre, the personalised service at this charming hotel captures the essence of congenial hospitality. Walking down the property's gardens has its own rewards, but you could also take a shikara ride into the sunset, or maybe just watch the hues of the dipping sun from the comfort of the lounge. Though the dining offers many options, including Kashmiri, nothing beats an evening barbecue grill by the lake.
(hoteldaressalaam.com; INR 8,750 plus taxes with breakfast)

Kani Home



Kani Home is a well-crafted, carefully curated, multi-disciplinary hub that welcomes artists, art enthusiasts and people with a spirit of creativity. This one-of-its-kind studio hosts wellness and craft retreats, and is exclusively open to people who enrol in these programmes. The rooms here are purely ancillary, providing a standard level of comfort. The property is a great option for travellers who want to combine soaking in Kashmir with an experience-driven stay.
(kanihome.kashmir@gmail.com; prices vary with programme)



Nadis, Srinagar

DAL LAKE

Sukoon Houseboat

Floating amidst a lotus and hyacinth bed, the Sukoon houseboat, true to its name, sits calm and steady on the gentle waters of Srinagar's Dal lake. A typical, ornate Kashmiri houseboat that is fitted with modern comfort, customary cuisine and contemporary hospitality, Sukoon is an amalgam of different worlds that meet on these placid waters. Head out on a shikara and explore this water world, with boat-swains swishing by, selling their wares, honeymooning couples on their dreamy boat rides and the gentle dipping of oars of resident commuters and travellers being ferried. Return to your houseboat for some 'sukoon', and get lulled to sleep in your gently rocking stay; there is nothing like waking up to the Pir Panjal with a cup of warm kahwa on the rippling waters of Kashmir.
(abchapriretreats.in/sukoon-houseboat; INR 16,220 with breakfast and taxes)

PAHALGAM

The Pahalgam Hotel

One of the earliest hotels in Pahalgam (95 km from Srinagar), the old-world charm of this property is unmistakable. Established in 1931, the hotel remains a Bollywood shoot favourite, and is loved by loyal, old-time travellers, too. Not just does it now have a new wing with contemporary rooms, its older rooms have also been refurbished. The views of the Lidder river, multi-cuisine comfort food and a familiar cosiness, all make for a winning combination.
(pahalgamhotel.com; INR 15,000 with lunch and dinner, plus taxes.)

Alpine Inn

An endearing cottage by the Lidder river, which originates in the Kolahoi glacier, the Alpine Inn gets almost everything right—scenic beauty, comfort, quiet and wholesome food. While carpeted walls and wood panelling add to its aesthetic, one's stay at the property is made even warmer with the electric blankets and hot water bags it provides in each room. Located just outside the main town, the riverside stay makes possible walks in neighbouring forests and also trips to the Aru Valley and Turin Lake nearby.
(alpineinnpahalgam.com; INR 4,500 with breakfast)